HIDDENATLAS

CURATED TRAVEL GUIDE

PHILIPPINES · PALAWAN

Philippines

17 Day Island Journey

DESTINATION	DURATION	IDEAL FOR
Philippines, Palawan	17 Days • 15 Nights	2–6 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

Philippines · Palawan · 17 Days • 15 Nights

DAY 1
Manila · Intramuros

DAY 2
Manila · Puerto Princesa · Underground River

DAY 3
Puerto Princesa · El Nido

DAY 4
El Nido · Big Lagoon · Small Lagoon

DAY 5
El Nido · Secret Lagoon · Shimizu Island

DAY 6
El Nido · Nacpan Beach

DAY 7
El Nido · Coron (overnight ferry)

DAY 8
Coron · Kayangan Lake · Twin Lagoon

DAY 9
Coron · Barracuda Lake · Shipwrecks

DAY 10
Coron · Pass Island · Malcapuya Beach

DAY 11
Coron · Boracay · White Beach

DAY 12
Boracay · Puka Shell Beach

DAY 13
Boracay · Ariel's Point

DAY 14
Boracay · Bulabog Beach

DAY 15
Boracay · White Beach

DAY 16
Boracay · Caticlan · Manila

DAY 17
Manila

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- El Nido's Bacuit Archipelago — private boat through the limestone karst islands
- Coron's WWII Japanese shipwrecks — among the world's best wreck dives
- Boracay's northern shore — the quiet end of the island the resorts avoid
- Kayangan Lake, Coron — voted the cleanest lake in Asia
- Twin Lagoon — two lagoons connected by a limestone arch you swim through
- Puerto Princesa Underground River — a UNESCO World Heritage site

DAY 1

Manila — Intramuros & the Night Market

Arrive at Ninoy Aquino International Airport and transfer to Intramuros — the Spanish walled city built in 1571, the oldest district in Manila and the most legible piece of the city's history. Fort Santiago, the Manila Cathedral, Rizal's cell. Dinner in the Binondo district: Chinatown, the oldest in the world outside China, where the food is better and cheaper than anywhere else in Manila.

- Intramuros — the Spanish colonial walled city at the mouth of the Pasig River
- Fort Santiago — the 16th-century citadel where José Rizal was imprisoned before execution
- Manila Cathedral — the Baroque cathedral rebuilt seven times since 1581
- Binondo Chinatown — the world's oldest Chinatown, established 1594

PHILIPPINES

DAY 2

Puerto Princesa — the Underground River

Fly to Puerto Princesa, Palawan's capital, and transfer to the underground river: a 24-kilometre navigable cave river system through a limestone karst landscape, a UNESCO World Heritage Site and one of the new Seven Wonders of Nature. The boat goes eight kilometres inside the cave. Return to Puerto Princesa. Van north toward El Nido along the coast road.

- Puerto Princesa Subterranean River — 24km cave river system, navigable by boat for 8km
- St Paul Mountain — the limestone massif above the underground river mouth
- Sabang Beach — the village at the river mouth, accessible only by boat or jungle trail

PHILIPPINES

DAY 3

El Nido — Arrival & the Town

Arrive in El Nido: the small town on the northern tip of Palawan, surrounded on three sides by karst limestone towers and on the fourth by the Bacuit Bay. The town itself is low-key — a single main street, beach bars, tricycles. But from here the Bacuit Archipelago is accessible by boat, and it is among the most beautiful collections of islands and lagoons in the world. This evening is for orientation.

- El Nido town — the gateway to the Bacuit Archipelago and Palawan's north
- Bacuit Bay — the sheltered bay facing the 50-island Bacuit Archipelago
- Las Cabanas Beach — the sunset beach south of town, reached by tricycle

PHILIPPINES

DAY 4

El Nido — Tour A: Big Lagoon, Small Lagoon & Seven Commandos Beach

The standard Tour A by private boat: Miniloc Island's Big Lagoon by kayak — the most photographed lagoon in Palawan, its turquoise water surrounded by vertical limestone walls. Small Lagoon reached through a gap in the rock at low tide. Snake Island sandbar. Seven Commandos Beach for the afternoon. Snorkelling over the reef between stops.

- Big Lagoon, Miniloc Island — a turquoise enclosure ringed by vertical limestone
- Small Lagoon — accessible only at low tide through a narrow rock passage
- Seven Commandos Beach — the white sand beach on Palawan's west coast
- Snake Island sandbar — the S-shaped isthmus appearing at low tide

PHILIPPINES

DAY 5

El Nido — Tour C: Secret Lagoon, Shimizu Island & Matinloc Shrine

The second essential El Nido island route: Secret Lagoon on Miniloc, accessed through a narrow rock crevice. Shimizu Island for the best snorkelling in the archipelago — the coral is intact and the fish density is high. Matinloc Shrine on its limestone cliff above the sea. Helicopter Island beach for the afternoon — the island shaped exactly like a helicopter from above.

- Secret Lagoon — a hidden enclosure accessed through a gap in the limestone
- Shimizu Island — the best coral reef in the Bacuit Archipelago
- Matinloc Shrine — the white cliff shrine above the Tapiutan Strait
- Helicopter Island — the white beach below the island's distinctive silhouette

PHILIPPINES

DAY 6

El Nido — Nacpan Beach & the North

The day away from the islands. Drive north to Nacpan Beach: a four-kilometre undeveloped white sand beach in the north of Palawan, facing the South China Sea, with almost no facilities and almost no crowds. One of the finest beaches in the Philippines, and one of the least visited because reaching it requires a dirt road and patience.

- Nacpan Beach — 4km of undeveloped white sand facing the South China Sea
- Twin Beaches viewpoint — the hill above where Nacpan and Calitang beaches converge
- Calitang Beach — the neighbouring beach that Nacpan connects to at low tide

PHILIPPINES

DAY 7

Ferry to Coron — the Overnight Crossing

Take the fast ferry or overnight boat from El Nido south through the Calamian islands to Coron: a different world from Palawan's north. Coron sits above the Calauit islands in the Busuanga group, and its underwater landscape — sunk Japanese supply ships from the Second World War, now colonised by coral — is among the most extraordinary in Southeast Asia.

- El Nido to Coron ferry — the 4-hour fast boat or overnight ferry through the Calamians
- Coron town — the small market town on Busuanga Island above the WWII wreck sites
- Coron Bay — the sheltered bay flanked by karst limestone islands

PHILIPPINES

DAY 8

Coron — Kayangan Lake & Twin Lagoon

The day the Philippines is best known for. Kayangan Lake: a 20-minute hike over a limestone ridge leads to the lake hidden inside the karst — the clearest freshwater lake in Asia, fed by mountain springs and shaded by vertical stone walls. Twin Lagoon: two lagoons connected by a limestone arch you swim through. Barracuda Lake in the afternoon: a thermocline dive.

- Kayangan Lake — consistently voted the cleanest lake in Asia, inside a limestone karst
- Twin Lagoon — two lagoons connected by a rock arch, the second warmer than the first
- Barracuda Lake — a thermocline lake where different water temperatures meet in a single dive
- Coron Island — the Tagbanua ancestral domain, accessible by permission

PHILIPPINES

DAY 9

Coron — WWII Japanese Shipwrecks

The wreck dives. On 24 September 1944, a US Navy air strike sank 24 Japanese supply ships in Coron Bay. Twelve are now diveable at depths between 10 and 40 metres, colonised by coral and fish, some with their cargo still intact. The Okikawa Maru, the Irako, the Olympia Maru. Non-divers can snorkel the shallower wrecks. There is nothing else like this in Southeast Asia.

- Okikawa Maru — the tanker wreck at 10–47m, accessible to snorkellers
- Irako — the provisioning ship wreck at 40m with intact structure
- Morazan Maru — the largest of the Coron wrecks at 33m
- Lusong Gunboat — the Japanese gunboat wreck in 10m, accessible by snorkel

PHILIPPINES

DAY 10

Coron — Pass Island & Malcapuya Beach

The above-water day. Pass Island for a morning of white sand and clear water. Malcapuya Beach in the afternoon: the uninhabited island with the white sand that Boracay used to have before the hotels arrived. Almost no one here on a weekday. This is the Philippines as it was before the infrastructure caught up.

- Pass Island — the small reef island north of Busuanga with snorkelling around it
- Malcapuya Beach — the uninhabited island with undeveloped white sand
- Banana Island — the long sandy islet visible from the Malcapuya approach

PHILIPPINES

DAY 11

Flight to Boracay — Arrival at White Beach

Fly from Busuanga to Caticlan, then take the 10-minute bancaferry crossing to Boracay. The island is four kilometres long with most of the tourism concentrated on White Beach — a 4km arc of white sand with infrastructure ranging from excellent to excessive. The northern shore is different: quieter, less developed, the original Boracay.

- White Beach, Boracay — the 4km arc of white sand that made the island famous
- Station 1 — the quieter northern end of White Beach, the best accommodation zone
- D'Mall — the commercial centre and useful orientation point
- Bulabog Beach — the east-coast kite and windsurfing beach facing the Sibuyan Sea

PHILIPPINES

DAY 12

Boracay — Puka Shell Beach & the North

The quiet Boracay. Puka Shell Beach on the northern tip: the longest beach on the island's quiet side, named for the shells that accumulate on its shoreline, with no sunbeds and no vendors. Walk to the lighthouse above Diniwid Beach. Sail the paraw outrigger at sunset — the traditional Filipino wooden sailing canoe that navigates White Beach every evening.

- Puka Shell Beach — the undeveloped northern beach, named for its shell shoreline
- Diniwid Beach — the small cove north of White Beach, accessible on foot
- Boracay paraw sailing — the traditional outrigger at sunset on White Beach
- Willy's Rock — the small volcanic rock with a Marian shrine in the White Beach shallows

PHILIPPINES

DAY 13

Boracay — Ariel's Point & the Last Reef

Morning boat to Ariel's Point: the headland off Boracay's north coast with cliff jumps from five different heights, snorkelling and free kayaking. Return for a final afternoon on White Beach. Dinner at the Station 1 end — the quieter restaurants that don't face the sunset strip, where the food is better and the price reflects it.

- Ariel's Point — the day-trip headland with cliff jumps at 3m, 5m, 8m and 15m
- White Beach sunset — the Boracay institution, the reason the island became famous
- Station 1 dining — the quieter end of White Beach with the island's better restaurants

PHILIPPINES

DAY 14

Boracay — Bulabog Beach & the East Coast

The half of Boracay that most visitors miss. Bulabog Beach on the island's eastern shore faces the Sibuyan Sea and catches the trade winds, making it the site of the Philippines' best kitesurfing. The beach itself is narrower and less manicured than White Beach, with outrigger boats instead of sun loungers. Walk the cross-island trail connecting the two coasts: fifteen minutes through coconut groves, the island narrowed to a few hundred metres.

- Bulabog Beach — Boracay's east coast, the kitesurfing and windsurfing shore facing the Sibuyan Sea
- The cross-island trail — the 15-minute path through the island's narrow interior linking both coasts
- Mount Luho viewpoint — Boracay's highest point at 100 metres, with open views across both shores
- Talipapa market — the small local wet market behind D'Mall, where the island actually shops

PHILIPPINES

DAY 15

Boracay — Final Day on White Beach

The last full day on the island. White Beach in the early morning before the beach fills is the calmest and most beautiful hour on Boracay: the fishing bancas still returning, the sand unoccupied. A slow morning, a long lunch at the Station 1 end, and a final paraw sailing at sunset — the traditional outrigger canoe that navigates White Beach every evening.

- White Beach at dawn — the most peaceful hour on Boracay's main beach, before the crowds arrive
- Station 1 restaurants — the quieter northern end of White Beach, the island's best dining
- Paraw sailing at sunset — the traditional Filipino outrigger canoe, the Boracay institution
- Willy's Rock — the small volcanic rock with a Marian shrine standing in the White Beach shallows

PHILIPPINES

DAY 16

Boracay to Manila — the Return

Morning ferry from Boracay to Caticlan. Flight to Manila's Ninoy Aquino International Airport. If the schedule allows, the BGC district is thirty minutes from the terminal: a final afternoon in the Philippines' most contemporary neighbourhood, with rooftop restaurants and the kind of evening meal that sends you home content.

- Boracay to Caticlan ferry — the 10-minute crossing to the Malay mainland
- Caticlan to Manila — 1-hour domestic flight on Cebu Pacific or Philippine Airlines
- Manila BGC — the Bonifacio Global City dining district near the airport, the city at its most current

PHILIPPINES

DAY 17

Departure from Manila

International departure from Ninoy Aquino International Airport. The Philippines stays with you: the colour of the water inside Kayangan Lake, the scale of the karst towers from a boat in Bacuit Bay, the stillness of the lagoons at Coron. Most destinations fade. This one doesn't.

- NAIA Terminal 1 — for most international carriers including Cathay Pacific and Finnair
- NAIA Terminal 3 — for Philippine Airlines, Singapore Airlines and major Gulf carriers
- Direct connections to Hong Kong, Singapore, Tokyo, Dubai and European hub airports

HIDDENATLAS

Ready to make this trip yours?

This guide gives you the structure and route.
Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
- Carefully selected areas to stay
- Logistics guidance for a smooth journey
- Insider tips from on-the-ground research

START PLANNING YOUR TRIP
hiddenatlas.travel/custom

© HiddenAtlas · hiddenatlas.travel